

Statement of Interest
Brodey Miller

My interest in computer science stems from the joy of problem solving and a recognition of its foundational role in modern society. Over time I have focused on cybersecurity and privacy, driven by the increasing corporatization of the digital world and the growing number of users vulnerable to unseen and unknown threats. Information is both a commodity and a target in our modern society, and censorship remains a real threat, so I seek to contribute to the development of effective network defenses. I am pursuing graduate school to engage in meaningful research, to educate and teach others about computer science, and to deepen my technical expertise in a community of genuine and passionate people.

To me, research is tackling a multitude of problems from different angles, and my research in Human Factors has shown me the human side of problems. Understanding that issues can be systemic or folded into how the human body works provides insights for designing interaction with computer systems. For instance, during my time working on the UMTRI-US ARMY Handbook, the lack of consistent measurements and definitions drove automotive research to be poorly used and implemented. Finding, synthesizing, and organizing information is a challenge when studies measuring similar or the same thing cannot be directly compared. Encouraging the use of a primary definition while providing others for compatibility evolves into an attempt to address the foundation of science while it is still moving forwards. Ultimately the value of research is not solely in academics, but in applications of that research; it is making research useful to the world that gives it value.

Graduate school at Western will allow me to take the lessons I've learned and apply them to the things that I am interested in learning more about. The strong focus on network systems and applicable ideas in the Western Information and Networking Group, and among faculty like Dr. Fang Fang and Dr. Fadlullah, would be avenues for me to explore these interests in computer security and a more efficient and private internet. These resources at Western are ideal for me to grow into my niche, and discover how we can secure computers better.

Human Computer Interaction is intertwined with security. Some problems can be tucked behind the scenes, but others may require direct interaction with a user. Understanding the challenges involved, and making computer systems secure but accessible, is a problem that research and education can give me the opportunity to solve. The skills I hold can shape the world as a more fair place. I believe I can be the person that I needed during my university experience for someone else, and guide them towards their goals. I want others to feel the community that exists in these areas of scholarship rather than the faceless institution that surrounds them, and to be in a position where I can be passionate about both teaching students and doing work.